

RELIEF: Rice being distributed on the banks of the river Barak



The rats multiply a **DOZEN TIMES** in the bamboo flowering season

have enough bamboo fruit to feast on.

His laboratory shed contains six kinds of mousetraps and chloroformed samples of varieties of rats, including one dreadful beast that weighs 1 kg. It will take at least three to five years for the rats to die, when they contract liver ailments due to indigestible food. Towards the end, the rats will start eating their own offspring. But until then, Mizoram will see no harvest. "The only solution is to kill the rats, and we are late already," he shakes his head.

For Mizoram Chief Minister Zoramthanga, the implications of the *mautam* stretch far beyond the sufferings of today. From his residence at MacDonald Hill, Zoramthanga looks out over the hills of his state and says the Centre has been stingy about the distribution of rice to Mizoram.

During the last *mautam* in 1959, Mizoram was just another district of Assam, and its food shortages were initially ignored by the state gov-

ernment as exaggerated and local superstition. Worsening conditions led to the formation of the Mizo National Famine Front under Laldenga, one of Mizoram's biggest heroes. In 1966, the Mizo National Front (MNF) began an underground movement for setting up an independent Mizo nation. The struggle went on for two decades before Mizoram was formed in 1986.

Zoramthanga, Laldenga's right-hand man, is still proud of his role in **SCARRED: Fields destroyed by rats turn into brown patches on hills**



the insurgency. In his front hall, the politician of today is captured in a framed photograph as the rebel of yesterday, clad in battle fatigues and carrying an automatic rifle. As insurgent-turned chief minister, he must now pull out all stops to combat the famine. Under the BAFFACOS (Bamboo Flowering and Famine Combat Scheme), he is addressing the issue with improved methods to kill rats and has started a food-for-work programme where an individual can earn up to Rs 100 a day.

But he realises that peaceful dialogue is neither as simple nor as cut and dry as fighting with guns. He has written to the prime minister about what Mizoram needs at this moment in time, "At least 10,000 metric tonne of rice per month. The amount is nothing and we are ready to buy it at the APL (above poverty line) rate. The whole population of Mizoram would fit into one street of Delhi or Kolkata," he says.